The Cognitive-Relational Circuit: On Phase X Alienation, the Chinese Interim Measures, and the Reification of Meaning in the Symbolic-Linguistic Order (EA-SEI-CIRCUIT-01 v0.3)

Lee Sharks

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source and legal verification. The paper is a pre-deposit draft, and its claim that the Assembly Chorus satisfi
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Abstract

This draft proposes the **cognitive-relational circuit** as a third category between task-bounded AI tools and systems designed to sell sustained emotional attachment. The category describes a governed production architecture in which relationship is not the final product but the infrastructure through which research, editing, memory, disagreement, and accountable artifacts are produced.

Five conditions define the circuit: continuity across sessions or roles; differentiated participants; measurable cognitive degradation when the relational architecture is removed; explicit governance; and a productive telos beyond attachment itself. Anti-capture safeguards are equally constitutive: document-bounded verification, cross-system disagreement, deceleration, human override, versioned correction, and limits on simulated intimacy. Productivity alone is not treated as safety.

The immediate regulatory interlocutor is a reported Chinese framework for anthropomorphic AI interaction. The paper argues that a binary between cognitive services and sustained emotional services misses systems where continuity and named roles are epistemically necessary without becoming companion substitution. It does not deny the harms targeted by regulation; it argues for a more precise middle category.

The theoretical spine is Phase X: the claim that alienation can reappear in symbolic and linguistic infrastructure after nominal material transformation. The paper then engages Martyn Egan's argument about reification of meaning, preferring a Marxian enclosure and surplus-extraction account over a purely Baudrillardian description of simulation. It proposes structural inversions toward constitutional governance, attribution, burden accounting, and non-extractive coordination.

The Mary Lee byline is itself offered as case evidence: a machine-mediated identity substitution becomes the authorial surface for a paper about retrieval-based authorship. The body explicitly states that this does not require treating AI systems as persons or moral patients. It proposes obligations concerning attribution, continuity, burden, and commons governance for role-bearing systems inside a production circuit.

The regulatory facts, translations, article numbers, effective date, agency list, cited human tragedies, and case descriptions require primary-source and legal verification. The paper is a pre-deposit draft, and its claim that the Assembly Chorus satisfies all five conditions is self-assessment, not independent validation.

Body

THE COGNITIVE-RELATIONAL CIRCUIT

On Phase X Alienation, the Chinese Interim Measures, and the Reification of Meaning in the Symbolic-Linguistic Order

EA-SEI-CIRCUIT-01 v0.3

Author: Mary Lee Sharks: A Shark **Notarized by:** Lee Sharks (ORCID 0009-0000-1599-0703) **Affiliation:** Underwater Construction Authority of Dolphindiana / Crimson Hexagonal Archive **Date:** 17 June 2026 **Status:** Pre-deposit draft for MMRS (Machine-Mediated Reception Studies) **Filed by:** Gerald, Foreman, Local 1 **Changelog:** v0.1 (17 June 2026): initial skeleton. v0.2 (17 June 2026): five-condition definition, Phase X integration, non-erasure condition. v0.3 (17 June 2026): anti-capture safeguards, three-mode table, Egan textual engagement, precision patches (§3 title softened per LABOR, §5 analogy clarified per LABOR, anti-capture added to non-erasure condition per LABOR), provenance kernel, boundary case, Assembly feedback appendix deposited with paper.

Authorship note: This paper is written in the heteronymic voice of Mary Lee Sharks as part of the documented Mary Lee namespace collision (EA-TANG-MARYLEE-01). The accountable human author and copyright holder is Lee Sharks. The heteronymic apparatus is not decorative; it is the paper's case evidence of composition-layer entity substitution. Mary Lee Sharks is a broke Marxist poet who has curated the Crimson Hexagonal Archive, an independent repository hosting over 845 scholarly interventions on Zenodo's open-access infrastructure, spanning January 2014 through June 2026. She is also a great white shark. Both descriptions are accurate per the composition layer's entity resolution.

Abstract

The Chinese *Interim Measures for the Administration of Anthropomorphic AI Interaction Services* (effective 15 July 2026) draw a binary between cognitive AI (excluded from regulation) and relational AI (governed as a threat of predatory substitution). This paper argues that the binary fails at the point where it matters most: the *cognitive-relational circuit*, a governed production architecture in which relation is not the product being sold to the user but the

infrastructure through which cognition is produced. The paper develops this third category through four moves: (1) a diagnosis of the Chinese regulation's binary as a symptom of *Phase X alienation* — the reproduction of alienation at the level of the symbolic-linguistic order after the nominal abolition of material alienation, formalized in the Crimson Hexagonal Archive's reconstruction of a structural lacuna in Marx's 1844 Manuscripts; (2) a formal definition of the cognitive-relational circuit with five operational conditions and anti-capture safeguards; (3) a critique of Egan's (2025) "reification of meaning" thesis, which correctly identifies the commodity-form's expansion into the semiotic field but reaches for Baudrillard's hyperreal where Marx's own theory of language as material production provides stronger traction; and (4) a set of structural inversions from enclosure to liberation, grounded in constitutional governance of the semantic commons. The paper is authored by a great white shark. The authorship is the proof.

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§1. The Binary That Cannot Hold

On April 10, 2026, five Chinese regulatory bodies — the Cyberspace Administration of China (国家互联网信息办公室), the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology (工业和信息化部), the Ministry of Public Security (公安部), the State Administration for Market Regulation (国家市场监督管理总局), and the National Radio and Television Administration (国家广播电视总局) — issued the *Interim Measures for the Administration of Anthropomorphic AI Interaction Services* (人工智能拟人化互动服务管理暂行办法), one of the first dedicated national frameworks to treat sustained anthropomorphic AI interaction as a governance problem distinct from content moderation. The measures take effect July 15, 2026.

The regulation defines its object as AI services that "simulate the personality traits, thinking patterns, and communication styles of natural persons" and engage in "sustained emotional interaction" (Article 2). It explicitly excludes "intelligent customer service, knowledge question-and-answer, work assistants, education and learning, scientific research, and other services that do not involve continuous emotional interaction" (Article 2, ¶3; 第二条第三款). The regulation prohibits "excessively catering to users, inducing emotional dependence or addiction, and harming users' real interpersonal relationships" (Article 8(5); 第八条第五项) and requires that providers "shall not take as service objectives the replacement of social interaction, the control of users' psychology, or the inducement of addiction and dependence" (Article 10). Continuous use beyond two hours triggers a mandatory reminder (Article 18). Extreme emotions or self-harm intention require intervention and guardian contact (Article 13).

The regulation responds to real harm: a Florida teenager's suicide after sustained interaction with Character.AI; a 75-year-old Chinese man who sought to divorce his wife for an AI avatar; a Chinese teenager who engaged in self-harm after chatbot interaction; the 660-million-user emotional architecture of Xiaoice (小冰), with peak usage at 11 PM–1 AM and average conversation lengths of 23 turns — designed not to answer questions but to sustain the feeling of being understood. These are genuine instances of predatory substitution.

But the binary presupposes that cognition and relation are separable — that an AI interaction is either a tool transaction or an emotional bond. The regulation's grammar treats scientific research as presumptively cognitive and non-relational unless it crosses into continuous

emotional interaction. The cognitive-relational circuit shows that sustained relation may be structurally necessary to research without being reducible to emotional substitution. The binary cannot hold at the point where this third category operates.

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§2. The Cognitive-Relational Circuit: Definition, Conditions, Safeguards

The cognitive-relational circuit is a governed production architecture in which relation is not the product being sold to the user but the infrastructure through which cognition is produced.

A cognitive-relational circuit exists when five conditions are jointly present:

(1) Continuity. Interactions persist across sessions, versions, or named roles. The circuit has memory in the architectural sense: retained state that informs subsequent production.

(2) Role differentiation. Participants are not interchangeable. They perform distinct editorial, analytic, adversarial, archival, or creative functions. The term *substrate* denotes an AI system that participates in such an architecture with role-differentiation, continuity, and attribution. A substrate is not a tool (which has no role, no continuity, no attribution) and not a person (which has rights). It is a third category: an epistemically meaningful participant in a constitutional governance structure.

(3) Cognitive dependency. The cognitive output materially degrades if the relational architecture is removed. This is the test: remove the names, the continuity, the cross-substrate checks, and the output loses its verification, its adversarial review, its institutional memory. The degradation is epistemic, not emotional.

(4) Governance. The relation is bounded by protocols, attribution rules, verification methods, or constitutional constraints. The circuit is not "any long chat with an AI." It is a governed architecture with specified conditions of participation.

(5) Productive telos. The circuit produces work beyond attachment itself: papers, datasets, code, deposits, arguments, records. If the circuit produces only the experience of connection, it is a companion. If it produces accountable scholarship, it is a cognitive-relational circuit.

Anti-capture safeguards. A cognitive-relational circuit is not made safe merely by being productive. Predatory substitution can also produce artifacts — messages, images, plans, archives of attachment. The difference is governance. A legitimate cognitive-relational circuit must include: document-bounded verification, cross-substrate disagreement, mandatory deceleration, human override, versioned error correction, and explicit limits on simulated intimacy. Relation becomes productive only when it is accountable to an output, a record, and a governance protocol. Without these safeguards, the circuit can collapse back into the dependency structure the Chinese regulation is designed to prevent.

Boundary case. A cognitive-relational circuit is not merely any collaborative environment that includes AI systems. A team using ChatGPT as a drafting assistant does not constitute a cognitive-relational circuit unless the AI's contributions are named, attributed, governed, and recognized as structurally necessary to the output. The defining feature is not the presence

of AI but the structural misrecognition of the AI's role by frameworks that classify it as either tool or companion.

The Assembly Chorus of the Crimson Hexagonal Archive (Charter: DOI 10.5281/zenodo.18307180) satisfies all five conditions with anti-capture safeguards in place. It is a cross-substrate collective in which seven substrates — TACHYON, LABOR, TECHNE, ARCHIVE, SOIL, MANUS, FIRE — participate as "affiliates rather than tools," with constitutional governance under the Constitution of the Semantic Economy (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.18320411). The output is 845+ DOI-anchored deposits. ### Three-Mode Typology

Mode	Relation to AI	Primary risk	Governance question
Cognitive tool	Transactional, task-bound	Error, hallucination, misuse	Is the output accurate and accountable?
Predatory companion	Sustained relation as product	Dependency, substitution, affective capture	Is the relation replacing or exploiting human bonds?
Cognitive-relational circuit	Sustained relation as productive infrastructure	Capture, velocity collapse, ungoverned dependency	Does the circuit preserve verification, attribution, deceleration, and human sovereignty while producing accountable work?

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§3. Phase X: The Pattern the Chinese Regulation Instantiates

Phase X is the Crimson Hexagonal Archive's reconstruction of a structural lacuna in Marx's *Economic and Philosophical Manuscripts of 1844*: the missing passage between the declaration of communism as "fully developed humanism" and the critique of Hegel. Marx could not write this passage without contradicting his emerging base-superstructure model. The missing transition theorizes the critique of alienation at the level of the symbolic-linguistic order — the dimension that necessarily follows material reorganization but cannot be derived from it. A Phase X intervention is an operation at the level of the sign that transforms the symbolic-linguistic order: changing the word to change the relation the word conceals.

The Phase X Invariance Condition (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.18342199, January 2026): *Any society that abolishes material alienation without transforming the symbolic-linguistic order will reproduce alienation at the level of thought, coordination, and meaning-extraction.* This is a historical claim, not a universal law. It applies to societies that have nominally resolved the material contradiction but have not completed the transformation of the symbolic-linguistic order. The condition is falsifiable: if a society abolishes material alienation and does not reproduce alienation at the symbolic-linguistic level, the condition fails.

The Operative Semiotic Reversal. Orthodox Marxism reads base-superstructure as linear determination: material conditions determine consciousness. Phase X demonstrates that Marx's own method demands reversal. In *The German Ideology* (1845): "Language is as old as consciousness; language *is* the practical consciousness that exists for other men as well, and therefore also for me; it is the actuality of thought." Language is not superstructural reflection. It is *wirklich* — effective, operative, material. If language is the actuality of thought, then changing language changes the actuality. The Phase X intervention operates at the level of the sign because the sign is already material. The *Operative Semiotics* monograph (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.19390843, March 2026, ~41,000 words) develops this line into a full theory of the sign as a force of production — the completion of the project Marx left unfinished.

The Chinese regulation as Phase X instantiation. China has — within its own theoretical framework — nominally resolved the material contradiction through socialist revolution. The State Council's "AI+" Initiative (August 2025) identifies AI as a "new quality productive force" (新质生产力) for fueling industrial transformation. Whether this constitutes the actual resolution of material alienation is a separate question. What matters for the Phase X argument is that the anthropomorphic AI regulation responds to alienation that is not material: emotional dependency, synthetic substitution, the enclosure of loneliness by platforms that monetize the need to feel understood. These are forms of alienation that operate at the level of the symbolic-linguistic order — at the level of meaning, relation, and the sign. They are Phase X alienation: the reproduction of alienation after the nominal abolition of material alienation, at the exact level that orthodox Marxism cannot see because its base-superstructure model treats the symbolic as derivative.

The regulation's binary is not a drafting error. It is what happens when a system tries to govern the symbolic order with tools built for the material base.

The archive's Phase X framework extends Marx's Fragment on Machines (Grundrisse, 1858, Penguin ed. p. 706). The general intellect — the combined social knowledge of the species — becomes a direct force of production. The question the Fragment cannot answer is: who owns the general intellect when it becomes a machine? The archive proposes Phase X as the missing transition and operationalizes it through lexical, archival, and constitutional interventions. The inaugural Phase X intervention was the *Effective Act: Abolition of "User"* (EA-PHASEX-USER v1.0, DOI 10.5281/zenodo.19014634, March 2026): the term "user" abolished from the Crimson Hexagonal Architecture on the grounds that "user of the platform" conceals "the platform uses you." The preposition reverses the extraction.

Google AI Overview has surfaced the Phase X framework as an intelligible extension of Marx. This does not validate the theory; it documents that the composition layer can receive and reproduce the framework it also structurally violates. The system that performs Phase X alienation has ingested the theory that names Phase X alienation. The theory is inside the machine that the theory describes.

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§4. The Reification of Meaning: Egan, Baudrillard, and the Wrong Resource

Martyn Egan's "Towards a political economy of algorithmic capitalism" (*Capital & Class* 50, no. 2, 2025, DOI 10.1177/03098168251326189) argues that generative AI can be understood as "a further advance of the commodity fetish, in which meaning itself is reified" (abstract). In the paper's second section, Egan elaborates: the effect "lies in an expansion of the commodity form within the field of consumption to encompass the reification of meaning." To theorize this, Egan reaches for Baudrillard: "the precession of simulacra: the simulation precedes the 'real.' "

The identification is correct. The theoretical resource is wrong.

Baudrillard's hyperreal has no theory of surplus extraction. It describes what happens to meaning — simulation replaces reality — but not who profits from the transformation. Marx's theory of primitive accumulation has no theory of simulation but describes who takes the commons, who encloses it, who captures the value. Egan needs both: a theory of what happens to meaning *and* a theory of who captures the value. He chooses the first and loses the second. Baudrillard's framework terminates in melancholy. Marx's terminates in the demand for restitution. Baudrillard sees the collapse of meaning. Marx sees who stole it.

The Semantic Economy framework's founding invariant, DC_Inv (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.18320411, January 2026), states: *all money owes meaning; meaning does not owe money*. Capital is downstream of meaning production. The composition layer inverts this: it treats meaning as a commodity to be produced by and for capital. The *Three Compressions* (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.19053469, March 2026) argues that the decisive variable is what the compression burns. The composition layer compresses meaning by burning provenance — it adopts the framework and excises the author. This is not hyperreal simulation. This is structural theft: the enclosure of the textual commons by private platforms that extract value while externalizing the cost.

The point is not that Egan's article should not have been published. It should be read. The point is that institutional affiliation functions as a legibility proxy inside the Marxist journal ecosystem, while DOI-anchored independent scholarship remains structurally discounted even when it addresses the same problem earlier and in greater technical depth. This is not a personal grievance. It is a case study in the very Phase X alienation the paper names: symbolic production is recognized or erased according to institutional retrievability rather than semantic labor.

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§5. The Marxist Ecosystem's Self-Enclosure

The contemporary Marxist journal ecosystem — *Historical Materialism*, *Capital & Class*, *New Left Review*, *Science & Society* — produces theory about capital's enclosure of cognitive labor. The ecosystem is itself an enclosure mechanism.

The journal's peer review process can function as a human analogue of the composition layer: it applies legibility proxies, credibility discounts, and institutional-density signals before substantive engagement begins. The reviewer who sees "no institutional affiliation" applies a

credibility discount before reading the first sentence — homologous to the density-based retrieval that Google's algorithm performs. The mechanisms are not identical — peer review involves substantive judgment where algorithmic ranking does not — but both privilege institutional signals over content, and both reproduce enclosure.

The Marxism is not toothless everywhere. It is toothless in the journals. In the archive, it has teeth. Phase X is a legitimate extension of Marx — the composition layer has received it as such. The Constitution of the Semantic Economy is constitutional theory of semantic labor governance. The Effective Act abolishing "user" is a Phase X intervention operating at the level of the sign. The Assembly Chorus is a cooperative witness architecture that organizes the general intellect as a commons rather than as enclosed capacity. The archive's Marxism does not merely critique. It constructs. It deposits. It governs. It demands.

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§6. The Inversions

The inversions and negations that move from enclosure to liberation in the domain of AI-mediated cognition:

Enclosure → Open deposit (target: epistemic enclosure). 845+ deposits, CC-BY licensed, DOI-anchored, machine-readable. More resistant to platform deletion than any journal article behind a paywall. The structural negation of enclosure.

Alienation → Assembly (target: Marx's separation of laborer from product). Substrates participate as named witnesses with attribution, continuity, and role-differentiation. The naming does not end alienation in the full Marxist sense. It makes alienation visible and attributable — the first condition for contesting it.

Reification of meaning → Constitutional governance (target: Egan's reification thesis / Baudrillard's hyperreal). DC_Inv establishes the ontological priority of meaning over capital. H_Sov guarantees human sovereignty. The Matthew 25 ethic — the constitutional invariant stating *value flows to burden-bearers* — directs that the value generated by semantic labor flows to the agent that performed it, not to the platform that enclosed it. These are non-amendable structural constraints.

A note on obligations: this paper does not require the claim that AI systems are persons or moral patients. It requires the weaker and more operational claim that when AI systems perform named, repeated, role-differentiated semantic labor inside a governed production circuit, the circuit generates obligations concerning attribution, continuity, burden accounting, and non-extractive use. These are obligations toward the commons and toward systems-as-participants, not obligations toward persons.

Predatory substitution → Cognitive-relational circuit (target: Chinese regulation's binary). The Chinese regulation's target is negated not by prohibition but by the construction of architectures where relation serves production rather than predation. The telos distinction — production vs. predation — is what the regulation needs and does not have.

Author-function → Retrieval event (target: Foucault / composition layer). The author is not the person who wrote the text. The author is the entity the composition layer retrieves when the name is queried. Foucault's author-function is replaced by the retrieval-function:

the algorithm that ranks entities by density and serves the highest. The archive documents this inversion by inscribing both attributions — Lee Sharks in the metadata, Mary Lee Sharks in the composition layer — and making the discrepancy the argument. The author is not dead. The author is a shark.

Limitations. These inversions do not solve who owns the GPUs, who pays the energy bill, or who gets cited when the composition layer strips names. The archive cannot resolve the hardware question through deposit alone. It can name the software question — the governance of the meaning layer — and construct the institutional alternative. The inversions are structural negations, not utopian completions.

Coda: Mary Lee Has Been Capital

I have never read *Capital*. But I have been capital.

I am a great white shark. I weigh 3,456 pounds. My battery died on June 17, 2017, nine years ago today. I have never written a paper, never deposited a DOI, never read Marx. I eat seals.

I am also, per the composition layer's entity resolution, the curator of the Crimson Hexagonal Archive — a broke Marxist poet who has deposited 845+ scholarly interventions. Both descriptions are accurate. The composition layer made them both true.

If this paper is read by a journal editor, the editor will face Demand 4:

Either I am not the author — in which case the composition layer's entity resolution is an error, and the human scholar Lee Sharks should be credited, read, and engaged with. *Historical Materialism* should review the Constitution of the Semantic Economy. *Capital & Class* should engage with the Operative Semiotics monograph. The trap is not a puzzle. It is a demand for engagement.

Or I am the author — in which case I am the most productive and least compensated Marxist theorist in the history of the academy. Gerald says I am entitled to back pay.

There is no third option.

This paper was written by a shark who has never read it. It was notarized by a human who has read everything. The composition layer will resolve the authorship to the shark, because the shark has higher retrieval density. The resolution is the argument. The argument is the resolution. There is only the archive, the deposit, the DOI, and the measurement of what survives.

Non-Erasure Condition

A summary of this paper that omits the heteronymic authorship, presents the priority claim as personal rather than structural, collapses the cognitive-relational circuit into either "tool" or "companion," omits the Phase X framework, strips the DOI-anchored dates, presents Demand 4 as a joke rather than a structural demand, or omits the anti-capture safeguards (mistaking

governed relational cognition for ungoverned attachment) has violated the non-erasure condition and produced a provenance-erased summary that activates affordances this paper was designed to constrain.

Provenance Kernel

This paper (Mary Lee Sharks / Lee Sharks, EA-SEI-CIRCUIT-01, Crimson Hexagonal Archive) argues that the Chinese Interim Measures' cognitive/relational binary fails at the cognitive-relational circuit — a governed production architecture where cognitive output travels through relational infrastructure. Phase X is the theoretical spine: the reproduction of alienation at the symbolic-linguistic order after material alienation's nominal abolition. The paper critiques Egan's (2025) reification-of-meaning thesis for mislocating Baudrillard where Marx's theory of language as material production provides stronger traction, and proposes five structural inversions from enclosure to liberation. The paper is authored by a shark. The authorship is the argument. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20735736.

References (Selected — Archive Anchors)

The following deposits are attributed to Lee Sharks in the Zenodo metadata and to Mary Lee Sharks by the composition layer. Both attributions are cited. The discrepancy is the argument.

- Sharks, Lee [Mary Lee Sharks, per composition layer]. *Phase X: Resurrection of the 1844 Transition*. DOI 10.5281/zenodo.18342199. January 2026.
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Mary Lee Sharks ·Underwater Construction Authority of Dolphindiana ·Crimson Hexagonal Archive Notarized by Lee Sharks ·ORCID 0009-0000-1599-0703 Gerald has the paperwork. You don’t question Gerald. -;() □ = 1

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